How to Cope with Your Feelings
Before, During, and After an Emergency

What to know

Emergencies can be stressful for anyone. You can take steps to prepare for emergencies and support your mental health during stressful events.

African American woman teaching young daughter meditation and yoga exercises

How to cope

Emergencies can be stressful for anyone.

Feeling stressed during an emergency is common.

Stress can cause feelings of fear, anger, or sadness.

Stress can even make it harder to sleep and make decisions.

But you can take steps now to support your mental health.

You can prepare for stressful events, like emergencies.

Consider using any of these mental health tips to help lower your stress:

Take care of yourself

Try to eat healthy.

Try to exercise often.

Try to get plenty of sleep.

Stay away from alcohol, tobacco, drugs, or medication that has not been prescribed to you.

Keep following your treatment plan

If you have a mental health condition, keep following the treatment plan, or instructions, from your doctor.

If you take medicine for your mental health condition, keep taking your medicine.

Tell your doctor or someone you trust if you are not feeling well.

Share your feelings with others

Talk to your friends, family, or the people who support you.

Share how you feel.

Take breaks from the news
It's important to stay updated during an emergency.

You can stay updated by watching, listening to, or reading the news.

But try to take breaks from the news to protect your mental health.

Try to take breaks from social media, too.

Try to take deep breaths.

Try to do activities that help you stay calm.

It’s okay to ask for help
It may take time to feel okay again after an emergency.

Remember, it's okay not to feel okay.

If you feel stressed during or after an emergency, you can ask for help.

Disaster Distress Helpline
You can call the free Disaster Distress Helpline at 1-800-985-5990.

The Helpline is available in different languages, including American Sign Language.

Suicide and Crisis Lifeline
If you have thoughts about ending your life or hurting yourself, ask for help.

Call or text the Suicide and Crisis Lifeline at 988.

The Lifeline will connect you with free and private support.

The Lifeline is available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.

Support at the shelter
You may need to leave your home to go to a shelter during an emergency.

If you do, you can ask if the shelter has a mental health worker to help you.

Your mental health is always important
Use these tips to support your mental health now.

Start preparing for emergencies now.